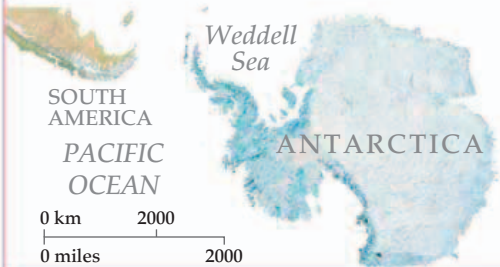


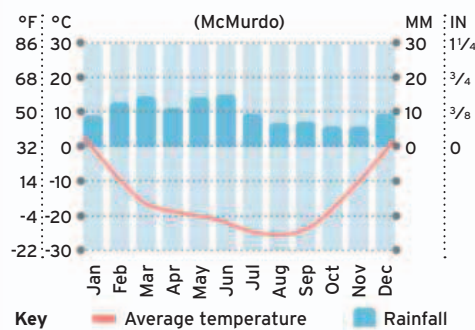
LOCATION

The peninsula is the northernmost part of Antarctica, separated from Cape Horn by the Drake Passage.



CLIMATE

Summer temperatures average 34°F (1°C); winter temperatures can drop to 5° to -4°F (-15° to -20°C) in the northern tip, lower in the south.



Leopard seal

Hydrurga leptonyx



Named for its spotted coat, this aquatic mammal is an expert hunter, thanks to its almost snakelike head and wide, powerful jaws with long canine teeth. Although it is the only true seal that feeds on other seals, up to half of a leopard seal's diet consists of tiny, shrimplike krill, and it has a set of specially adapted cheek teeth that serve as a sieve for feeding on them.

Different strokes

Unlike other true seals, the leopard seal swims not by propelling itself solely with its hindquarters, but by strong, simultaneous strokes of its large, elongated front flippers. This technique gives the seal increased speed and agility in the water, but makes it difficult for the animal to move around on land. Females are slightly larger than males—the opposite of size differences in most true seals. Females give birth on pack ice to single pups, which are suckled for three to four weeks.

Although they are the most formidable carnivores in their ecoregion, leopard seals are occasionally hunted by killer whales. Seals are protected from commercial hunting, but juveniles, which depend largely on krill to survive, may also be threatened by a decrease in krill numbers due to commercial overfishing.

- ↔ 8–12 ft (2.4–3.7 m)
- ⚖ 440–1,000 lb (200–455 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐟 Krill, squid, seals, penguins
- 🏠



Southern Ocean and subantarctic waters

▽ OPPORTUNISTIC PREDATOR

Leopard seals patrol penguin rookeries in search of young, newly fledged penguins, which are more vulnerable to attacks.



Leopard seals **vocalize underwater**, making **long-lasting calls**, some of which can be **felt through ice**

than 70% of its fresh water

FLIGHTLESS INSECT
Antarctica's only insect is flightless and so avoids the constant buffeting winds. It tolerates high salinity and loss of body water, and its black color absorbs heat. By living in shallow burrows, the midge survives temperatures just below freezing.

ANTARCTIC MIDGE

